

THE FREE SIGNUP GIFT · THE BI-WEEKLY ONE-SHOT

THE DM'S FIELD KIT

Seven tables, a d100 villain engine, and three field methods for any table, in any fantasy game.

Long Island Dungeon Master · system-agnostic · 5e-compatible

Here's the thing nobody tells you when you start running games: the prep is never the problem. The problem is the moment the party does something you didn't write down, and four people are looking at you, and the silence is getting expensive.

This kit is for that silence. Tables you keep open in a tab or print on a few sheets, built so you can roll once and have something true to say in the next five seconds. No theme, no setting, no system to learn. They drop into whatever game you're already running.

30+ years of running games (basements, kitchen tables, the back rooms of game shops) and every row here is a note I wish someone had handed me sooner. The test for keeping a row was blunt: it has to give you something to say in the next five seconds, and that something has to hand your players a decision. Rows that were just scenery got cut and rewritten until they passed.

Eleven tools below. Seven are quick tables: who the people are and what they actually want, the tic you'll remember them by, the room, the loot, the town that's already on edge when you ride in, and the worst roll of the night. One is the centerpiece: a d100 for what your villain is doing while the party isn't watching. And three are field methods, new to this edition: a cold-open table that starts any session inside its first decision, a spine for ruling anything the book forgot, and the bridge that turns the villain d100 into a campaign engine instead of a party trick.

1. THIS NPC IS NOT WHO THEY SEEM

Roll when the party leans on a "minor" NPC harder than you planned, and you need that NPC to have a second floor under the first.

Most NPCs are exactly what they look like. The interesting ones aren't. Each row gives you who they seem to be, who they actually are, and the tell, the one detail a careful player can catch before the reveal, so the twist feels earned instead of cheap. Drop the tell early. Pay it off later.

D20	SEEMS TO BE...	ACTUALLY IS...	THE TELL
1	A nervous shopkeep	The fence who moved the stolen goods, scared the party found him	Counts coins twice, won't take the marked one
2	A drunk at the bar	The only sober witness to the murder, drinking to forget the face	Flinches at the victim's name, not the noise
3	A grieving widow	The one who arranged the death and is now afraid she'll be caught grieving wrong	Cries on cue, eats with appetite
4	A helpful guide	Leading the party the long way to give his employer time to clear out	Knows shortcuts he never offers
5	A temple beggar	A disgraced priest who still hears confessions no one knows they're giving	Repeats your own words back, slightly cleaned up

D20	SEEMS TO BE...	ACTUALLY IS...	THE TELL
6	A loyal old servant	Skimming the estate for thirty years, now blackmailed by someone who noticed	Two sets of ledgers, one for show
7	A captured prisoner	The bait, planted to be rescued and walked straight into the camp	Wrists chafed, but the rope was tied loose
8	A wandering healer	Carrying the plague on purpose, paid to seed it town by town	Never gets sick, never stays long
9	A by-the-book guard captain	A man one bribe past the point of caring, waiting for the offer	Looks at the gate, not the threat
10	A simple farmer	The retired killer the party's been hunting, hoping the past stays buried	Hands too steady for the plow
11	A cheerful innkeeper	An informant who sells every guest's business by morning	Remembers names too well
12	A child lost in the market	The lookout, counting the party's purses for the crew down the alley	Not crying for a parent, watching the doors
13	A rival adventurer	A debtor who took a job to deliver the party, not to help them	Generous with drinks, vague about the patron
14	A pious pilgrim	Hauling something in the reliquary that should never have left its box	Won't set the case down, even to eat
15	A harmless fortune-teller	A blackmailer reading guilt off faces and selling silence	Her "visions" are last week's gossip
16	A devoted apprentice	The one who poisoned the master slowly, learning the trade in the meantime	Quotes the master in the past tense too soon
17	A town hero	The arsonist who set the fire so he could be the one who saved them	First on every scene, always
18	A frightened messenger	Carrying a sealed order to have the reader killed, and he knows it	Hands the letter over fast, won't make eye contact
19	A kindly stranger paying your tab	Recruiting for a debt the party won't know they signed until later	Generosity with no ask is the ask
20	Exactly who they seem	And the party will never believe it, which is its own problem	Nothing. That's the tell.

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice when you want layers: the first roll is the mask the party sees, the second is what's under it when they peel the first one back. (A "grieving widow" hiding a "retired killer" is a better villain than either alone.)



2. WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN THIS ROOM

Roll when the party opens a door you didn't detail, and "it's an empty room" would kill the momentum.

Dungeon dressing usually means furniture. This is dressing that hands the players a decision the second they walk in. Every row is a small fork: take it, use it, break it, or leave it and wonder. Read the bold thing aloud; keep the part after the dash for yourself.

D20 IN THE ROOM...

- 1 **A table set for a meal, food still warm:** someone left in the last minute and might be watching, or coming back
- 2 **A locked chest already pried open and empty:** someone beat the party here; the question is who, and where they went
- 3 **A wall of small doors, each with a different name carved above it:** one of the names belongs to a party member
- 4 **A well with a rope going down and a bucket coming up on its own:** something below is hauling, and it expects company
- 5 **A fire that gives no heat and casts the wrong shadows:** the shadows show what the room looked like a hundred years ago
- 6 **A child's room, dust-free in a building of dust:** someone cleans it; find out who, and you find out a lot
- 7 **A map of the dungeon on the wall with one room circled in red:** it's the room the party most wants to avoid, and now they know
- 8 **A pile of weapons, all bent the same direction:** whatever did that is still in the building
- 9 **A door warm to the touch with quiet voices behind it:** the voices stop the moment a hand touches the wood
- 10 **A statue holding a real, usable lever:** pulling it does something, somewhere, that the party won't see from here
- 11 **A floor of dried mud with one set of fresh tracks leading in and none leading out:** do the math
- 12 **A cage with the door open and the lock bitten through:** from the inside
- 13 **A shrine with fresh offerings and no congregation for miles:** somebody walks a long way to keep this fed
- 14 **A ledger left open mid-entry, the ink still wet:** the last line names someone the party knows
- 15 **A bed, slept in, and a second one never touched but kept ready:** for a guest who's expected and overdue
- 16 **A row of portraits with one face scratched out:** the same face, in every painting, no matter the body
- 17 **A pool of clear water with a key at the bottom, just out of arm's reach:** and the water's colder than water should be
- 18 **A trail of blood that's been mopped, badly, in a hurry:** leading to a wall with no door in it
- 19 **A music box still playing, winding itself when it slows:** it stops if anyone says the wrong name, and starts again at the right one
- 20 **A mirror reflecting a room that isn't this one:** and there's a way into that other room, if the party's foolish enough

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice for a room with a layer: the first roll is what they see, the second is what they find when they actually search it. (Warm food on the table, and the ledger underneath naming the cook.)

3. THE REWARD HAS A STORY

Roll when the party earns loot and you want it to mean something past the gold-piece value: a string attached, a door it opens, a problem it becomes.

Treasure with no story is just a number on a sheet. Every item here carries a hook: a consequence, a lead, or a person who wants it back. Hand it out freely. The hook does the work later.

D20 THE REWARD...

1	A purse of coin, every piece stamped with a face that's now illegal to carry
2	A fine sword with another family's crest, and that family is still looking for it
3	A signed letter of credit worth a fortune, drawn on a bank that just collapsed
4	A ring that opens one specific door somewhere, and someone wants to know who's wearing it
5	A map to a second cache, drawn by a hand that wanted whoever followed it to die
6	A jeweled holy symbol from a faith that punishes theft of its relics personally
7	A debt owed to the previous owner, now owed to whoever holds the marker: the party
8	A beautiful weapon that the last three owners all died holding; the smith remembers each one
9	A locked box the party can't open, and the only person who can open it is the one it was stolen from
10	A title deed to land the party has never seen, currently occupied by people who won't leave
11	A potion that works exactly once, and two dying buyers who each need it, and the party can only sell to one
12	A masterwork tool stolen from a guild that brands thieves and has a long memory
13	A favor in writing from a powerful person, redeemable once, who has since changed sides
14	A child's toy worth nothing, that a very dangerous someone will pay anything to recover
15	A set of keys, no labels, and one of them fits a door the party walks past every day
16	A trained animal that obeys its dead master's commands and no one else's, yet
17	A cloak that belonged to a wanted person; wearing it means wearing their face to those who knew them
18	A ledger of names, half of them crossed out, the survivors worth knowing or worth avoiding
19	A gem that's clearly a payment for something that hasn't happened yet, with a date inside
20	A perfectly ordinary, perfectly valuable hoard, and the rumor of it travels faster than the party does

QUICK KEY

Rows 1-6 are loot that's *hot* (someone wants it back). Rows 7-14 are loot that's a *lead* (it points somewhere). Rows 15-20 are loot that's a *slow burn* (the problem shows up sessions later). Pick the timing your table needs.

4. FAIL FORWARD

Roll when a check fails and "nothing happens" would stall the whole night. The failed roll doesn't stop the story; it bends it.

The deadliest words at any table are "you don't find anything." A failed roll should cost something or move something, never just end the turn. Roll on this when you're stuck for what a failure *does*. The party still doesn't get the clean win. They get a complication they have to deal with instead.

D12 INSTEAD OF NOTHING...

- 1 They succeed, but it takes far longer than they have, and something arrives in the meantime
- 2 They succeed, but loudly: whatever they were sneaking past now knows they're here
- 3 They get it wrong in a way that looks right, and won't learn the truth until it matters
- 4 They succeed, but it costs a resource: a broken tool, a spent charge, a torn map
- 5 They learn half of it: enough to act, not enough to be safe
- 6 Someone else solves it first, and now the party owes them
- 7 They succeed, but leave a trace that leads someone right to them later
- 8 The attempt works on a delay; it'll pay off at the worst possible moment
- 9 They hit a different problem they didn't know was there, and have to deal with that first
- 10 They succeed, but only one of them can carry it forward. Who, and what gets left behind?
- 11 The information is true but planted; acting on it walks them into someone's plan
- 12 They succeed completely, and that's the trap: it was meant to be found

HOW TO USE IT WITHOUT IT GETTING SAMEY

Don't roll every failure. Save this for the rolls that *matter*: the locked door to the only exit, the negotiation the whole session hinged on. A clean failure is fine when the stakes are low. Pull this out when "nothing happens" would put four people on their phones.



S. MANNERISMS & TICS

Roll when an NPC needs to exist as a person five seconds after you invent them. Give them one habit and the players will remember them all night.

A name is forgettable. A tic isn't. Hand an NPC one physical or verbal habit and the players will start calling them "the one who keeps cleaning his glasses" before they ever learn his name, and that's the NPC who survives the session in their memory. Some of these reveal something true about the person. Some are just texture. A few will make the table lean back. Grab one mid-sentence; you don't have to know why they do it yet.

D20 THE NPC...

- 1 Touches a scar when they lie, every time, and has no idea they do it
- 2 Never finishes their sentences, and somehow you always know how they end
- 3 Laughs half a beat too late, like they're waiting to be told it's funny
- 4 Cleans something that's already clean: a cup, a blade, the same spot on the table
- 5 Calls everyone by the wrong name on purpose, and gets yours exactly right once, to make a point
- 6 Answers a question with the question, buying the second they need to decide whether to lie
- 7 Keeps one hand on whatever they'd grab if this goes wrong
- 8 Smiles with the mouth only; the eyes are doing a different job
- 9 Counts on their fingers under the table when they think, and stops the instant they're watched
- 10 Repeats the last word you said, quietly, before they reply, tasting it
- 11 Won't sit with their back to a door, and rearranges the room to fix it without comment
- 12 Apologizes for things that aren't their fault and never for the things that are
- 13 Eats while they talk about something terrible, and stops eating when it gets personal
- 14 Picks at a wedding ring that isn't there anymore
- 15 Speaks to the most powerful person in the room even when answering someone else
- 16 Hums one tune, the same six notes, when the lying gets hard
- 17 Overshares one true thing early so the next ten lies go down easy
- 18 Watches your hands, not your face: a habit from a life they don't mention
- 19 Goes very still when they're afraid instead of fidgeting, and gets calmer the worse it gets
- 20 Keeps glancing at the empty chair, and answers a question nobody asked, before catching themselves

QUICK KEY

Rows 1, 6, 11, 14, 17, 18 *reveal* something: a lie, a fear, a past, a tell a sharp player can read. Rows 2, 3, 4, 8, 12, 16 are pure *texture*. They make the NPC stick without meaning anything. Rows 19 and 20 run *unsettling*. Use them on the NPC you want the party to distrust before they know why. Roll twice for a person, not a prop: a tic that reveals plus a tic that's just them.

6. WHAT THIS NPC ACTUALLY WANTS

Roll the moment a conversation gets interesting and you realize you never decided what the NPC across the table is really after.

Every NPC walks into a scene wanting something the party can't see on their face. Pin that down and the conversation steers itself. They'll dodge, push, flatter, or stall, and the players will feel a current under the words without knowing the source. This is the want *right now*, in this room, not the grand life goal. Read the bold part as the pressure they're putting on the scene; keep the dash for what it costs them if the party figures it out.

D20 WHAT THEY ACTUALLY WANT...

- 1 **To find out how much the party already knows:** every question they ask is the real conversation; yours is the cover
- 2 **To be talked out of something they've already decided:** they want permission, not advice
- 3 **To stall until someone else arrives:** the clock is the plan; the chat is the wait
- 4 **To get one specific name out of the party** without letting on that the name is all they came for
- 5 **To be seen as more important than they are:** flatter them and they'll give you the keep
- 6 **To confess, badly, to the wrong people:** the guilt is leaking and they can't stop the seam
- 7 **To sell the party something** they don't yet know they need, and make it feel like their idea
- 8 **To borrow the party's reputation:** to be seen with them, so others draw the wrong conclusion
- 9 **To get the party to leave** without making it obvious they want them gone
- 10 **To test whether the party can be bought:** the offer is real, the price is the information
- 11 **To apologize** to someone in the party who doesn't remember the wrong
- 12 **To pass a message** they're too scared to deliver straight, buried in small talk
- 13 **To keep the party here,** in this room, away from where the real thing is happening
- 14 **To find out if they're suspected yet:** and they'll overplay the innocence to check
- 15 **To recruit one party member** quietly, and split them from the rest
- 16 **To settle an old score** the party doesn't know they're standing in the middle of
- 17 **To be reassured** that the terrible thing they did was the only choice
- 18 **To get a look at one thing the party is carrying** without asking to see it
- 19 **To trade up:** they've got better information for sale than the party came for, if the party proves worth it
- 20 **Nothing from the party at all:** they're here for someone else in the room, and the party is furniture

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice for a two-faced scene: the want they'll admit to (the first roll) and the want driving them under it (the second). Someone "stalling until backup arrives" who *also* "wants to be talked out of it" is a scene that can break either way, and the party's choices decide which.

7. WHY THE TOWN'S ON EDGE

Roll when the party rides into a place you didn't fully prep and the locals are clearly bracing for something. Give the town a problem before the party even dismounts.

A town with nothing wrong is a town with nothing to do. The fix is to decide, before the party's boots hit the dirt, what's got the place wound tight: the thing everyone's talking around, the reason doors shut a little faster after dark. Each row is local tension the party can walk straight into. The bold part is what they'll notice; the dash is what's actually underneath, for you.

D20 THE TOWN IS ON EDGE BECAUSE...

- 1 **People have been going missing, one a week, always at night:** and the count is off by one; someone's hiding a body the party could find
- 2 **A stranger arrived three days ago and hasn't left their room:** the innkeeper's too frightened to ask them to
- 3 **The well's gone bad and nobody will say why:** the body in it belongs to someone important
- 4 **A festival's tomorrow and everyone's pretending to be excited:** the thing the festival is really for is the part they won't explain
- 5 **The militia's gone, marched out a week ago, and hasn't sent word:** the town is undefended and knows it
- 6 **Two families are one insult away from open blood:** and both are sizing up the party as hired muscle
- 7 **A debt's coming due and the collector isn't human:** the whole town's been paying into a pot that won't be enough
- 8 **Children won't go near the old mill anymore:** and the adults have started listening to why
- 9 **The priest stopped giving sermons a month ago:** and still takes the offerings, still locks the temple at night
- 10 **Livestock are dying in a pattern,** a straight line pointing at one house on the edge of town
- 11 **A hanging's scheduled for dawn and half the town thinks the prisoner's innocent:** the other half knows he is
- 12 **Strangers' faces are showing up on the wanted board faster than crimes are happening:** someone profits from arrests
- 13 **The mayor hasn't been seen in public in weeks:** the orders still come, signed, in handwriting that's changed
- 14 **A fire took the granary and the town's rationing:** and the fire started in the one building that was insured
- 15 **Every dog in town started barking at the same hour two nights ago and won't stop at that hour since:** it's the hour the old curfew bell used to ring, and nobody will say what the curfew was for
- 16 **The road in and the road out have both had "accidents":** the party may be the last travelers through for a while
- 17 **A wedding's off, violently, and both halves of the town took sides:** the bride knows something the groom's family wants buried
- 18 **The graveyard's short a few graves:** freshly empty, and nobody's admitting to a reburial
- 19 **A tax collector's overdue and a worse one is rumored to be coming instead:** the town's deciding whether to pay or run
- 20 **Nothing's wrong, loudly:** the town is too clean, too friendly, too quick to suggest the party move along by morning

QUICK KEY

Rows 1, 8, 10, 15, 18 run *eerie*: something's hunting or worse. Rows 6, 11, 17 are *human* tension the party can take a side in. Rows 5, 7, 14, 16, 19 are *pressure from outside* the party can shoulder or dodge. Roll twice and combine for a town with a fault line: the visible crisis (first roll) and the quieter rot under it (second) that explains why nobody's fixed the first.



8. WHAT THE VILLAIN IS DOING RIGHT NOW

The centerpiece, a d100. Roll it between sessions so your antagonist has a life the party hasn't earned access to yet, and the world keeps moving while the heroes sleep.

Your villain is only alive when the party is in the room with them. The rest of the week they sit in a drawer. That's the leak: a villain who only exists on-screen feels like a boss fight waiting to happen, not a person the world is afraid of. The fix is cheap. Between sessions, roll once. Decide what your antagonist is doing while the heroes sleep, travel, or argue about loot, then let it bleed into the next scene as a rumor, a changed map, a letter that beat them there. Most rows are grounded on purpose; the strangeness creeps in toward the end.

D100 THE VILLAIN IS...

- | | |
|----|---|
| 01 | Rereading the last letter from someone who's dead now, mouthing the words. |
| 02 | Practicing an apology they will never give, out loud, to an empty chair. |
| 03 | Counting something small and pointless (coins, teeth, days) to keep their hands still. |
| 04 | Eating the cheap food they grew up on, in a room full of better food. |
| 05 | Asleep at the desk mid-sentence, ink drying on their cuff. |
| 06 | Burning a portrait one corner at a time, then stopping before the face. |
| 07 | Cleaning a wound they won't let anyone see, humming to get through it. |
| 08 | Writing their own eulogy and editing it for flattery. |
| 09 | Talking to a pet, a plant, or a corpse as if it answers. |
| 10 | Standing at a window doing nothing, which is the most dangerous thing they do all week. |
| 11 | Firing a loyal servant for a mistake they'd forgive in themselves. |
| 12 | Overpaying a new recruit to find out whether money is enough to buy them. |
| 13 | Refereeing a petty feud between two lieutenants and enjoying it too much. |
| 14 | Drafting a will that cuts out the second-in-command, who doesn't know yet. |
| 15 | Promoting the one person too dull to ever betray them. |
| 16 | Listening at a door to hear what the staff say when they think it's safe. |
| 17 | Quietly poisoning the rival they smile at across the table. |
| 18 | Paying a healer to keep a useful prisoner alive and miserable. |
| 19 | Teaching a child of the household something gentle and true, for once. |
| 20 | Reading a report of their own cruelty and correcting the grammar. |
| 21 | Moving a marker on a map. A town the party likes just changed hands. |
| 22 | Signing the order the party is riding to prevent. They'll arrive a day late. |
| 23 | Bribing the one official who could have stopped all of this. |
| 24 | Testing the weapon, ritual, or plague on something small. It survives. That's the bad news. |
| 25 | Buying up debt, water rights, or grain: the boring lever under the whole scheme. |
| 26 | Burning the evidence that would have let the party expose them cleanly. |
| 27 | Sending a gift ahead to someone the party hasn't met yet, but will. |
| 28 | Cancelling the plan, then reinstating it an hour later, worse. |
| 29 | Recruiting the exact ally the party was counting on. |

D100 THE VILLAIN IS...

- 30 Doing nothing, because waiting is the plan, and they're better at it than the heroes.
- 31 Handing out bread with their own hands, and meaning it.
- 32 Sitting with a dying tenant who has no idea who's responsible.
- 33 Settling a neighbor's dispute fairly, which is why the district loves them.
- 34 Lowering a tax to buy a year of quiet before the part that hurts.
- 35 Naming a building, a bridge, or a child after themselves.
- 36 Hearing out a petitioner's grief and filing it for later use.
- 37 Funding a school whose graduates will all owe them.
- 38 Pardoning a criminal in public for a favor collected in private.
- 39 Weeping at a funeral they caused, and the tears are real.
- 40 Promising protection they fully intend to provide, on terms no one read.
- 41 Keeping a ritual they can't skip: same chair, same cup, same hour, or the day goes wrong.
- 42 Hiding a pain (a limp, a tremor, a cough) that's getting worse.
- 43 Spending real money on a vanity: teeth, a wig, a tailor, a singing voice.
- 44 Guarding a superstition they'd kill to keep secret.
- 45 Losing the slow fight against a vice they swore they'd quit.
- 46 Sleeping badly, in armor, with the door barred from the inside.
- 47 Collecting something harmless and odd: pressed flowers, music boxes, locks without keys.
- 48 Re-tying a child's shoe, an old reflex from a life they no longer admit to.
- 49 Forgetting a name they should know, and frightened by the forgetting.
- 50 Laughing, really laughing, at something stupid, and hating that they did.
- 51 Reading a description of the party and getting one detail flatteringly wrong.
- 52 Raising the bounty, then halving it when no one good will take the job.
- 53 Sending a letter instead of a sword. They'd rather hire the party than fight them.
- 54 Studying the party's last victory for what it taught them about the heroes.
- 55 Quietly relieved the party killed the lieutenant they wanted gone.
- 56 Baiting a trap with the one thing the party actually wants.
- 57 Inviting the party to dinner, sincerely, to see if a deal is possible.
- 58 Moving the thing the party is coming for, and leaving a polite note.
- 59 Mispronouncing the party's name on purpose, the only pettiness they allow themselves.
- 60 Rebuilding the whole plan around the party, the first time they've respected anyone in years.
- 61 Burning a uniform, a holy symbol, or a crest from the life before this one.
- 62 Meeting someone who knew them when they were kind, and going pale.
- 63 Paying off the last witness to a thing they did at twenty.
- 64 Visiting an unmarked grave at the same hour every month.
- 65 Opening a letter in handwriting they recognize and had hoped was dead.
- 66 Rehearsing the story of their innocence until they almost believe it.
- 67 Returning to the room where it happened and finding it smaller than the memory.

D100 THE VILLAIN IS...

- 68 Keeping the one thing they swore they'd thrown away.
- 69 Lying to a sibling, a teacher, or a god about how far they've gone.
- 70 Forgiving the person who ruined them: out loud, alone, and not meaning a word of it.
- 71 Negotiating with someone worse, and discovering they have a conscience after all.
- 72 Refusing an easy win because of a line they didn't know they still had.
- 73 Crossing a line they swore they wouldn't, and going quiet about it for days.
- 74 Saving an enemy's life for a reason that isn't mercy and isn't strategy.
- 75 Studying a rival they secretly admire and would never admit to fearing.
- 76 Paying tribute to a power above them, humiliated by how small it makes them.
- 77 Shielding a weak rival from a stronger one, like a farmer choosing which predator to keep.
- 78 Breaking a promise to themselves, the only oath they've ever kept.
- 79 Offering a truce the party would be fools to take and wiser to consider.
- 80 Letting a smaller villain take the credit, and the eventual fall.
- 81 Feeding the thing in the cellar, and apologizing to it.
- 82 Aging a year in a night, hiding the new gray every morning.
- 83 Talking to a reflection that answers a half-second late.
- 84 Paying a price in something that isn't money: a memory, a name, a year.
- 85 Reading a book that reads them back, and unable to stop.
- 86 Holding a door that shouldn't open shut with ordinary nails and ordinary prayer.
- 87 Bargaining with the dead, who are better at patience than the living.
- 88 Wearing a face that isn't the one they were born with, and forgetting which is real.
- 89 Arguing with advice from a voice only they can hear.
- 90 Bleeding something that isn't blood, and cleaning it up before the staff wake.
- 91 Pulling a child out of a fire they didn't set, on instinct, in front of a witness.
- 92 Drafting the order to free everyone, then locking it in a drawer.
- 93 Giving the party exactly what they asked for, to prove a point that costs lives.
- 94 Confessing the entire plan to a stranger who won't remember by morning.
- 95 Choosing the merciful option for once, being right, and resenting it.
- 96 Preparing their own death as carefully as anyone else's.
- 97 Realizing they've become the thing that made them, and continuing anyway.
- 98 Writing the party a letter that, if they ever read it, would end the war in peace.
- 99 Looking at the finished plan and feeling nothing they were promised they'd feel.
- 100 Stopping. Just stopping, and wondering, for one unbearable hour, who they'd be without it.

DECADE KEY, FOR THE DM IN A HURRY

01-10 alone, off the clock · **11-20** managing their people (the seams) · **21-30** advancing the plan (the clock ticks whether you watch or not) · **31-40** the people they claim to serve · **41-50** the body and the tell · **51-60** reacting to the party · **61-70** the past arriving · **71-80** rivals and the lines they hold · **81-90** grounded, then strange · **91-100** the turn that reframes them at the table.

9. THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

Roll before the session when you want to skip the tavern and start where things are already going wrong. Each row is a complete opening frame: the place, the problem, and the first call the players have to make.

Most sessions spend twenty minutes clearing their throat. You don't owe anyone a slow open. Start the party inside a situation that has already gone sideways, tell them how they got there in one sentence, and put a decision on the table before the snacks are open. Players will reconstruct the missing hour on their own, usually by arguing about whose fault it was, and that argument does your exposition for you. Read the bold part more or less as written; the dash is yours, and it tells you where the scene wants to go.

D12 THE SESSION OPENS ON...

- 1 **The wagon they were hired to guard is already burning:** the driver's gone, the horses are cut loose, and something inside the cargo crate is knocking to get out. First call: fight the fire, chase the driver, or open the crate
- 2 **A crier in the square is reading out their names:** a proclamation, a reward, and a crowd doing the math with its eyes. First call: step forward, slip away, or bid on themselves
- 3 **The funeral has started and the party has the body:** they're late with the coffin, and the eulogy drifting over the wall is telling a story about the dead man that they know is a lie. First call: interrupt with a corpse, or wait and learn what the lie is for
- 4 **Half the party is on the ferry that just cast off:** the ferryman was paid to leave the other half on the dock, and the man who paid him is standing there to watch it happen. First call: swim, shoot the tow rope, or ask him what he wants
- 5 **A stranger dies at their breakfast table mid-warning:** he got out a name, a place, and the word "tonight" before the poison finished. The cup he drank from was set at a party member's seat. First call: which of the three they chase
- 6 **They wake in a jail cell, unarrested:** nobody remembers being taken, the door isn't locked, and the guard slumped in the corridor is wearing somebody else's uniform. First call: walk out clean, or find out who needed them held for exactly one night
- 7 **One of them has a duel at noon and it's already eleven:** the challenge names an insult nobody remembers giving, and the challenger's second keeps checking a written script. First call: fight it, apologize for it, or prove it was staged before the bell
- 8 **The town they came to save doesn't need saving:** somebody did the job last night, took the pay, and left the party's names with the bodies. First call: run, hunt the impostors, or stand trial for a rescue they didn't perform

D12 THE SESSION OPENS ON...

- 9 **Their new employer is dead in the room that summoned them:** the contract's ink still wet, the payment counted out on the desk, and boots coming up the stairs. First call: the money, the body, or the window
- 10 **The heist is already collapsing when the scene opens:** the rope is cut, the alarm is ringing, and the inside man is not where the plan says. Start at the bad part; the players will invent the plan by arguing about where it broke
- 11 **Something of theirs is lot number seven:** the auction is three lots away from an item a party member lost years ago, and the reserve is more coin than they're carrying. First call: bid, steal it back, or find out who consigned it
- 12 **The dead man from their last job is knocking on the door:** alive, out of breath, and holding the thing the party was paid to bury with him. First call: let him in before whatever's chasing him rounds the corner

QUICK KEY

Rows 1, 4, 10 open *mid-action*: the body is already moving, and the dice come out early. Rows 2, 7, 8, 9 open *under accusation*: the party's name is in trouble before they've done anything. Rows 3, 5, 6, 11, 12 open *on a wrong fact*: something they thought they knew just stopped being true.

PICK, DON'T ROLL, WHEN TONIGHT'S PLOT NEEDS A SPECIFIC DOOR

And steal the shape even when you skip the table: name the place, name what's already wrong, ask "what do you do" inside the first five minutes. Pair a row with Table 7 for the where and Table 1 for the who, and the session builds itself. A night that opens on a decision stays awake; that's the standard every adventure I publish is held to, and it starts here.

10. THE RULING SPINE

For the moment a player says "can I..." and the book goes quiet. A four-beat method for ruling anything, then a d12 for when the scheme works, mostly.

Nobody's rulebook covers the bard greasing the stairs, the rogue marrying into the cult, or the wizard's plan involving a pig and two hundred feet of rope. Good. The stuff the book forgot is where the table earns its stories. You just need a spine so your rulings feel fair at speed, and it's four beats long:

1. **Intent.** Ask what they're after, not what they're doing. "I climb the chandelier" isn't a plan; "I want to be above the fight" is. Rule on the want. Half the time, saying the intent out loud shows both of you which roll actually matters, and sometimes it shows you no roll is needed at all.
2. **Stakes.** Before any dice, decide what failure costs. If failure costs nothing, don't roll. Say yes and keep the night moving. If you can't say what failure looks like, you're not ready to call for a check yet.
3. **The honest DC.** Set the number as if you hadn't heard the plan. Four numbers cover a whole career: **10** if anyone could, **13** if a professional could, **15** if a professional would sweat, **18** if the bards will sing about it. Say it out loud before the roll. A DC set after the dice land isn't a ruling, it's a veto, and players smell the difference.

4. Fail forward. A failed scheme changes the situation; it never ends it. Table 4 has you covered there. But a *successful* scheme you never saw coming deserves better than a flat “okay, it works,” and that’s what this d12 is for.

Table 4 is for when a die comes up short. This one is for when the plan you never wrote comes up *good*, and you want the world to notice. Roll it when an unplanned scheme succeeds and the success should have a shape.

D12 YES, BUT...

- 1 **Yes, but somebody helped:** the plan needed one unwitting hand: a porter, a clerk, a guard who looked away. That person now holds a piece of the story and is deciding what it’s worth
- 2 **Yes, but it worked too well:** the diversion meant to move one guard moved the whole watch, and the exit now runs through the crowd they created
- 3 **Yes, but the mark played along:** the target saw through it halfway and let it happen. They’ll be by later to collect what the party owes them for the performance
- 4 **Yes, but it has a name here:** what they just did is a specific crime in this town, with a specific punishment, and one witness who knows both
- 5 **Yes, but it broke something adjacent:** the wall they dropped was holding up more than the door; the lie they told just knocked the legs out from under a truth an ally was standing on
- 6 **Yes, but the disguise has appointments:** the alias, the uniform, the forged writ worked because it’s real, and the real one is expected somewhere in the morning
- 7 **Yes, but the wrong audience loved it:** the trick fooled the target and impressed someone worse, who now wants the same work done for them and won’t ask nicely twice
- 8 **Yes, but it ate the tool:** the rope, the seal, the favor, the one scroll: the trick worked exactly once, and the world just watched them spend it
- 9 **Yes, but someone innocent wears it:** the blame lands on a bystander before the party has counted the take, and the arrest happens within earshot
- 10 **Yes, but the problem moved:** the thing they schemed around didn’t go away; it relocated, and its new position is worse for them than its old one
- 11 **Yes, but it holds until morning:** someone checks: a headcount, a ledger, a seal. The party knows exactly how long the trick stays bought, and it’s less time than they need
- 12 **Yes, and:** clean, no strings, better than anyone deserved. Bank it. The table will retell the night the stupid plan just worked, and the retelling buys you the next ten “buts”

ONE CAUTION

Don’t roll this on every scheme, or “yes” starts sounding like “yes, but” every time and the players stop scheming. Save it for the plans big enough to leave a mark on the world. Small cleverness just works. That’s the reward for being clever.

11. THE VILLAIN REMEMBERS

The bridge that turns Table 8 from a mood into a campaign engine: how one between-session roll becomes next week’s opening scene, and what the villain does when the party keeps not showing up.

Table 8 tells you what the villain did while the heroes slept. This is what you do with it. Between sessions, roll the d100 once, then ask one question: **how does the party find out?** There are only three carriers.

A rumor. Someone tells them: secondhand, paraphrased, wrong in one useful detail the party can chase.

A change. Nobody says anything. A price is different, a face is missing from its usual corner, a flag is new on a wall. The players who notice feel like detectives; the ones who don't will hear about it soon enough.

A message. The villain tells them himself: a letter, a gift, a summons, a body arranged to be found. Reserve this one; it spends the villain's mystique every time you use it.

Pick a carrier, put it in the first five minutes of the next session (Section 9 exists for exactly this) and write one line in your notes: *what the villain did, and who noticed.* That line is the villain's ledger. Three sessions of ledger and your antagonist has a life the party can feel moving under the floorboards. It costs you one roll and one sentence a week.

And the party will ignore some of it. Good. Ignored villain activity is fuel, not failure. Each time a roll reaches the party and they let it pass, climb one rung:

D10 THE SCREWS TURN...

- 1 **The rumor gets a name in it:** last month the taproom said "somebody." Tonight it says the villain's name out loud, and the room checks the door before repeating it
- 2 **A price goes up:** bread, passage, silence, a night's lodging: something the party pays for costs more now, and the extra coin travels uphill
- 3 **A door closes politely:** an ally is suddenly busy, an inn is full with empty rooms, a contact answers every question with weather. Nothing hostile. Everything colder
- 4 **A face changes sides:** someone the party knows by name is wearing the villain's colors and drawing the villain's pay, and isn't ashamed enough about it
- 5 **The map moves:** a village pays new taxes, a garrison sits where a market was, a road the party used last month has a toll gate and a ledger. Redraw something they've walked on
- 6 **Kindness gets audited:** the villain has worked out who's been helping the heroes, and the friendliest NPC the party knows gets a visit they only hear about afterward
- 7 **The offer arrives:** formal, generous, and real. The party's silence has been read as an opening bid, and the villain would honestly rather buy them than bury them
- 8 **The paperwork lands:** no thugs, just writs: a warrant, a debt called in, a bounty with a seal on it. The villain wields the law like a weapon that cleans itself
- 9 **The precious thing is taken, not broken:** whatever the party protects most is now held, unharmed, somewhere expensive to reach. Leverage, not ruin. The villain wants a conversation
- 10 **The villain stops hiding:** a public sermon, a festival in their honor, a coronation with open doors. The ladder ends in confidence: the party taught them fear wasn't required. The next move is the party's, and everyone is watching

RUNNING THE LADDER

Reset it whenever the party pushes back and it costs the villain something real. The ladder measures neglect, not time. Skip rungs when the roll deserves it: a Table 8 result from the strange decades (81-100) can jump straight to rung 9. And rung 10 isn't a fail state. It's a session, and usually the best one of the campaign.



ONE RECIPE, FOR THE NIGHT YOU HAVE NOTHING

The tools chain. If you're staring at a blank page an hour before the session, run this and you have a night:

1. **Table 7** gives you the town and what's wrong with it.
2. **Section 9** opens the session inside that trouble. Pick the frame that fits the row you rolled, don't roll blind.
3. **Tables 1 and 6** staff the scene: who the key NPC is under the mask, and what they want from the party right now. **Table 5** hands them the tic the players will remember them by.
4. When the party starts scheming, **the Ruling Spine** keeps you fair at speed, and **Table 4** keeps failure moving instead of stalling.
5. **Table 3** sends them home with loot that carries the next hook in its pocket.
6. After the session, roll **Table 8**, run it through **Section 11**, and next week's opening scene is already sitting in your notes.

That's a campaign, assembled out of an hour you didn't have. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and in the way that matters, there isn't one.



YOU'VE GOT THE TABLES. HERE'S THE WHOLE NIGHT IN ONE FILE.

The kit covers the gaps: the NPC you didn't write, the room you didn't stock, the villain who needed a life. There's a bigger version of the same promise.

Adventure Keepers are complete adventures in a single HTML file. Art, maps, a dice roller, an initiative and HP tracker, the adventure's own clocks, and saves. All of it runs offline from a laptop at the table. No books open, no browser tabs, no account. You open one file and the whole night is in front of you: the read-alouds written, the stat blocks sorted, the "when your players go off the rails" section already thought through. The three methods you just read (the five-minute open, the ruling spine, the villain who keeps moving) are the bones the format is built on.

The first one is free: **The Keeper of Halcyon Light**, a full adventure in the format. Run it once and you'll know inside ten minutes whether it's your kind of tool.

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Keepers drop into **Gnasher's Grimoire**, the free library that holds them: one place for every adventure you own, jump-around, offline, no account. **The Bi-Weekly One-Shot** is the newsletter this kit came from. Complete, ready-to-run sessions, free monsters, and tables like these: a villain with a reason, a real choice for the players, the twist already built.

No pressure. The tables work either way. See you at the table.



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